policy was ‘shaped almost exclusively’ by Nehru.[12] According to Murty India’s geography and the legacy of history may have created a certain environment but Nehru’s unique beliefs shaped India’s foreign policy, using circumstances and history as justification.

Nehru’s British education and his close ideological ties with British socialist intellectuals built during the 1930s and ’40s served as major influences on his persona. His foreign policy outlook had a touch of Fabian socialism and liberal internationalism along with a deep belief that a strong state – not the market – is critical for the growth and development of a country like India. The spirit of freedom that Nehru imbibed in England and his close observation of British parliamentary democracy made him an ‘uncompromising’ opponent of all forms of totalitarian rule. [13] Hence, Nehru sympathized with the Allies during the World War II, refused to meet with Mussolini in 1936 and supported the Congress decision to send fifty volunteers to help the leftist struggle against fascism in Spain.

‘NEHRUVIANISM’

Indians often refer to Nehru’s foreign policy as ‘Nehruvian’ and one might as well describe the ideas behind that policy as ‘Nehruvianism’. In his lifetime, Nehru avoided labels tied to his name, though he did speak of Gandhian principles. His mark on some ideas is so strong that they can only be associated with Nehru rather than with Gandhi or someone else. The key pillars of Nehruvianism were the concept that India was a great civilization that could regenerate itself at all times; the desire for independence and non-alignment in relation to great powers; a strong belief in economic autarky; and support for international institutions in maintaining global order and world peace. These ideas remain influential in Indian thinking to this day.

In his three-volume biography of Nehru, Sarvepalli Gopal, son of India’s second president Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, outlines Nehru’s belief that